

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Math	Advanced Math	Nonlinear functions	Hard

Question

Function f is defined by $f(x) = -a^x + b$, where a and b are constants. In the xy -plane, the graph of $y = f(x) - 15$ has a y -intercept at $(0, -\frac{99}{7})$. The product of a and b is $\frac{65}{7}$. What is the value of a ?

Correct Answer: 5

Rationale

The correct answer is 5. It's given that $f(x) = -a^x + b$. Substituting $-a^x + b$ for $f(x)$ in the equation $y = f(x) - 15$ yields $y = -a^x + b - 15$. It's given that the y -intercept of the graph of $y = f(x) - 15$ is $(0, -\frac{99}{7})$. Substituting 0 for x and $-\frac{99}{7}$ for y in the equation $y = -a^x + b - 15$ yields $-\frac{99}{7} = -a^0 + b - 15$, which is equivalent to $-\frac{99}{7} = -1 + b - 15$, or $-\frac{99}{7} = b - 16$. Adding 16 to both sides of this equation yields $\frac{13}{7} = b$. It's given that the product of a and b is $\frac{65}{7}$, or $ab = \frac{65}{7}$. Substituting $\frac{13}{7}$ for b in this equation yields $(a)(\frac{13}{7}) = \frac{65}{7}$. Dividing both sides of this equation by $\frac{13}{7}$ yields $a = 5$.